Ask it well

Lesson 6: asking a good question is a skill, and you can learn it.

Check the Source · 45 minutes

If you walked up to me and said "space"...

I'd ask what you want to know about space. The assistant usually doesn't ask. It **guesses**.
Today you learn to stop making it guess.

Weak and strong

Weak	Strong
tell me about space	How do astronauts sleep on the International Space Station?
climate	How does warming ocean water hurt coral reefs?
help with my report	I'm writing a report on the Dust Bowl. What caused it, and how did it change farming?
who is best president	Which U.S. presidents do historians rank highest, and why do they disagree?

The four parts

1

Subject

Exactly what it's about. "Gray wolves", not "animals".

2

Specific question

What you want to know. "What do they eat in winter?"

3

Purpose

Why you're asking. "For a report."

4

Limits

What you want back. "Three causes."

You don't need all four, but you need more than one.

Habits of good askers

- Use the words **a book would use**. "Coral bleaching" finds more than "why reefs look dead".
- Ask **one thing at a time**, then follow up.
- If the first answer misses, **change the prompt**. A prompt is a draft.
- **Leave out personal details**, yours and anyone else's.

Your turn: the prompt ladder

1

One word

"Wolves"

2

A specific question

What do you actually want to know?

3

Add a purpose or limits

Why, and what do you want back?

4

Go to the shelf

Check one claim against your best book.

Topics: gray wolves, volcanoes, the Civil War, the Dust Bowl, coral reefs, the Great Lakes, the moon landing.

What did you find?

- Which rung changed the **most**?
- Did a stronger prompt ever make things **worse**?
- Was your best answer also **true**?

> Very narrow questions can find fewer books. Go one step **broader for books**, and **narrower for the answer**.

Strong doesn't mean true

A strong prompt gets you a better answer, not a guaranteed true one. **Keep checking.**